Letter One

Rosecliff Cottage, Newport · the 11th of June, 1895

Dearest Sarah,

I have been in this house four days and have already committed at least two unforgivable sins, according to Mother: I laughed too loudly at Mrs. Fish's dinner, and I asked a Van Alen boy which regiment his father served in, when apparently everyone simply *knows*, the way one knows to breathe.

But Sarah · I am *out*. Finally, properly, indisputably out, and if I must endure a season's worth of small humiliations to earn the right to say so, I find I do not mind them nearly as much as I feared I would last winter, weeping into my pillow while you were off being married and marvelous in New York.

The invitations arrived this morning in a positive snowdrift · Mrs. Fish, the Wetmores, a lawn tennis party at the Casino, and (I confess I read this one twice) a card for the Ochre Court ball at the end of the month, which even Mother agrees is *the* invitation of June. She has been unbearable about it in the particular way she gets unbearable, which is to say radiant and terrifying at once, rearranging my wardrobe as though a gown might singlehandedly fix a husband to me by main force.

You will laugh, but Evelyn Rutherford was among the first to call. She came all sweetness and lace, sat exactly four minutes, and managed in that time to mention no fewer than three times how *unusual* it was for a girl to come out a year late, and wasn't it brave of me, and she did hope nothing had been *wrong*. I smiled the whole while and told her I'd simply been waiting for the right season to bother arriving in. She did not care for that answer. Good.

Papa is behaving oddly · more oddly than Mother's foolishness, which at least has a familiar shape. He keeps finding reasons I ought not overcommit myself this early, ought to wait and see who calls before deciding whom to encourage, as though I were buying a horse rather than attending parties. Mother says he has always been overcautious where I'm concerned and I shouldn't mind him. I try not to. But there is something in the way he watches the mail that I cannot quite account for.

Speaking of mail · a letter came from the Aldens in France, addressed as always to "the family," Thomas's hand at the bottom in a scrawl clearly added at the last moment: *hope the season treats you kindly, V.* Four words, Sarah. Four words, after two years, and I read

them roughly forty times before supper. I have decided I am furious with him. I have also decided to keep the envelope.

Write to me at once and tell me everything New York finds shocking this week. I intend to be equally shocking here, given the opportunity.

Yours, breathless and back-laced entirely too tight,
Violet